▼ GLASSHOUSE



# SAMAJWADI SHOWTIME

Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav** seems to have realised that if he wants to get heard over all the TV din, he needs to up his press briefings game. Which is perhaps why, lately, they have been doubling up as live mini-cultural performances. The latest 'event' was at the party office in Lucknow, where youth from the backward Vishwakarma community staged a full-on '*nukkad naatak*' in the middle of the presser. The act praised the last SP government (2012-17) and ended, predictably, with the message that the people's problems would be solved if Akhilesh returned to power. In recent months, other pressers have seen party workers and performers breaking into *shayari* and even 'Bhagavat Katha' recitals. Akhilesh, too, has been indulgent, handing out cash envelopes as a small prize to those bringing some colour to the proceedings.

*Illustrations by* **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ GANDHIS IN WAYANAD

# ON HER OWN TRIP

AICC general secretary and Wayanad MP **Priyanka Gandhi Vadra** picked the wrong time in September for her visit to her constituency. Her 10-day stay (September 12-22) proved a political non-event, reportedly leaving workers and voters disenchanted. Reels and social media updates from the trip fell flat, while her meetings with cultural figures like



Kalpetta Narayanan and M.N. Karasserry seemed tokenistic at best. Even the photo-op with tribal farmer and Padma Shri awardee Cheruvayal Raman failed to strike a chord. Most telling was her avoiding a meeting of the families of Congress leaders driven to suicide by party rivalries, an omission that angered many. The visit eventually resembled a family holiday with Sonia and Rahul Gandhi joining her on September 19.